



ACCESSIBILITY

DOC NO. RL-BRAND-001-A11Y-A REV. A RIPOSTE LABORATORIES

Riposte's base is exceptionally accessible – ink on bone is 15.39:1, more than double what WCAG AA asks. The risk in this system isn't the base. It's the accents.

CONTENTS

▶ 1 • The one thing to know	3
The fix, when you need one	4
▶ 2 • Accent-coloured text on bone	5
De-emphasis: <code>-text-muted</code> and <code>-text-faint</code>	5
▶ 3 • Colour is never the only signal	6
▶ 4 • Focus	7
▶ 5 • Motion	7
▶ 6 • Structure	8
▶ 7 • Type sizes	8
▶ 8 • Print	9
▶ 9 • The automated check	10

Full numbers: `color-reference.md` `RL-BRAND-001-COLOR-REFERENCE`, generated and verified on every build.

SEC.01

1 • THE ONE THING TO KNOW

bone on pink is 3.16:1. bone on teal is 2.27:1.

Both are **fixed brand rules**. Both **fail** WCAG AA for body text. This is not a defect to be fixed by changing the brand – it's a constraint to be respected by using those pairings only where they're legal:

LEGAL	ILLEGAL
.chip, .pill, SEC.NN numbers	Any paragraph
.spec and .verdict header rows	Any list of sentences
6px top bars, 8px left bars (no text)	Form labels and help text
Uppercase display at 24px+ or bold 18.66px+	Captions, footnotes, fine print
The .triband footer cell (short uppercase strings)	Links inside body copy

WCAG's "AA Large" threshold is **3:1**, and applies at 24px+ regular or 18.66px+ bold. bone on pink (3.16:1) clears it. bone on teal (2.27:1) **does not clear even that** – teal fills may carry short uppercase chrome as a brand convention, but never anything a reader has to parse. Where teal must hold real text, use -teal-deep.

THE FIX, WHEN YOU NEED ONE

Every accent has a text-safe deep variant. Same hue, same saturation, lightness dropped until bone clears 4.5:1:

BRIGHT (FILLS)	DEEP (TEXT-BEARING)	BONE ON DEEP
-pink #F0477D	-pink-deep #D81150	4.53:1 ✓ AA
-orange #FE9A0D	-orange-deep #A15E01	4.53:1 ✓ AA
-teal #12B795	-teal-deep #0C7A63	4.69:1 ✓ AA

Or invert: **ink on marigold is 8.12:1** – the best-contrasting accent pairing in the system, and the reason marigold is the correct fill for .note callouts, warnings, and anything else where the words matter more than the vibe.

SEC. 02

2 • ACCENT-COLOURED TEXT ON BONE

The other common trap. Two of the three accents **cannot be text on a bone page**:

	ON BONE	VERDICT
pink	3.16:1	Large/display only
orange	1.90:1	Never text
teal	2.27:1	Never text

A teal heading on a bone page must be `-teal-deep`. A marigold heading must be `-orange-deep` – and at 1.90:1 the bright version is nearly invisible to everyone, not just to low-vision readers.

Use `-accent-text` rather than naming a colour. It resolves correctly per field: `pink-deep` on bone, plain `teal` on ink (6.79:1 – already safe), `ink` on a pink field.

DE-EMPHASIS: `-text-muted` AND `-text-faint`

Every field carries two quieter tiers below `-text`. They are `color-mix()` expressions, so their real ratios appear nowhere in `tokens.json`, and until this revision nothing measured them. `scripts/build.js` now resolves the mixes and checks each tier against its own field; the full table is in `color-reference.md` RL-BRAND-001-COLOR-REFERENCE under **Semantic text tiers**.

FIELD	-text	-text-muted	-text-faint
bone	15.39:1	5.14:1 ✓ AA	3.74:1 – chrome only
ink	15.39:1	6.59:1 ✓ AA	4.12:1 – chrome only
pink	3.16:1	4.87:1 ✓ AA	4.87:1 ✓ AA

Two rules, both enforced by the build:

- ▶ **-text-muted stays body-legal.** On any field where `-text` clears 4.5, the muted tier has to clear it too. De-emphasis is a tone, not a licence to drop under AA.
- ▶ **-text-faint is chrome.** It clears the 3:1 large-text and non-text floor and nothing more. Corner marks, slash tags, unit labels. Never a sentence.

The pink field has one tier, not two. `bone` on pink is already 3.16:1 – there is no contrast left to spend, and mixing bone toward pink took `-text-muted` down to 2.36:1, no better than `ink-line` on `ink`, the value `01-color.md`_{RL-BRAND-001-COLOR} holds up as the trap to avoid. Both tiers now resolve to `-ink` (4.87:1), which on a hot field reads **quieter** than bone rather than louder. Past that, hierarchy on a pink field comes from size, weight and tracking, not colour.

opacity helpers are a separate risk the build cannot check. `.dim` at `.65` and `.slashtag` at `.6` composite against whatever is actually painted behind the element, which is a layout question rather than a token question. On bone and ink they land in the same band as the muted and faint tiers; on a pink field they fall below the floor along with everything else that tries to soften bone on pink. Treat them as decoration there.

SEC.03 3 • COLOUR IS NEVER THE ONLY SIGNAL

Every state in the system pairs a colour with a **glyph**:

✓	pass	teal	<code>.verdict.yes</code>
×	fail	pink	<code>.verdict.no</code>
!	warning	marigold	<code>.verdict.warn / .note</code>

This holds for charts too: series are distinguished by fill **and** by label, direct-labelled where possible rather than relying on a legend.

The accent rotation (pink → marigold → teal across cards) is decorative, not semantic. If a reader can't tell the three apart, they lose nothing – the content is identical. Never encode meaning in "the pink one".

SEC.04

4 • FOCUS

CSS

```
:focus-visible { outline: 3px solid var(--focus-ring); outline-offset: 2px; }
```

3px, not 2 – a 2px ring is indistinguishable from the system's structural 2px borders. The 2px offset separates it from the element's own border.

--focus-ring is pink on bone (3.16:1 against bone – clears the 3:1 non-text UI threshold) and teal on ink (6.79:1). **Never remove the outline.** The brand has no soft alternative to fall back on; there's no glow, no shadow, no colour shift subtle enough to substitute.

SEC.05

5 • MOTION

Motion is already minimal – 120/150/250ms, plain easing, no scroll-triggered fades, no parallax. The stylesheet still honours the preference:

CSS

```
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {  
  .marquee .track { animation: none; }  
  *, *::before, *::after {  
    animation-duration: .001ms !important;  
    animation-iteration-count: 1 !important;  
    transition-duration: .001ms !important;  
  }
```

```

    }
    .cta:hover, .btn:hover, button:hover { transform: none; }
  }

```

The `.marquee` ticker is the only continuous animation in the system, and it's the first thing to stop. Hover pops lose their `translate` but keep their colour inversion, so the state change is still visible.

SEC.06

6 • STRUCTURE

The visual system leans hard on borders and uppercase — neither of which conveys anything to a screen reader. So:

- ▶ **Uppercase is `text-transform`, never typed.** Type `Process`, style it uppercase. A screen reader announcing P-R-O-C-E-S-S as letters is a real failure mode, and text typed in caps also can't be searched or translated properly.
- ▶ **SEC.03 chips and DOC NO. marks are decorative chrome.** If they're not part of the document outline, mark them `aria-hidden="true"` so the heading reads as its title, not as SEC.03 THE COUNTER-ATTACK.
- ▶ **Glyph bullets come from `::before`,** so they're not in the accessible name. That's correct — ▶ shouldn't be announced. But ✓ and × in `.verdict` **do** carry meaning, so pair them with visually-hidden text (Pass:) or an `aria-label` on the list.
- ▶ **`.checker` and `.harlequin` bands are pure decoration.** `aria-hidden="true"`.
- ▶ **Heading levels follow the document, not the type scale.** A `-text-h3`-sized heading can be an `<h2>`. Size is a style; level is structure.

SEC.07

7 • TYPE SIZES

Body copy is 15px (16px on the homepage) — at or just below the conventional 16px baseline. Monospace at 15px reads larger than a proportional face at 15px because the x-height and character width are both generous, but:

-
- ▶ **Never go below 14px for prose.** `-text-md` (14px) is the floor for anything sentence-shaped.
 - ▶ The 10-12px steps are for uppercase labels only, where tracking keeps them legible.
 - ▶ Everything scales with browser zoom and `rem`-based user settings; nothing is locked to viewport units alone (`clamp()` always has a `px` floor).
 - ▶ `-webkit-text-size-adjust: 100%` prevents iOS from silently inflating text.

SEC.08

8 • PRINT

Print styles drop to true black on white, hide the decorative bands, and underline links. Structural rules go to **1.5pt minimum** – below 1pt, a 2px screen rule disappears at press and the entire visual structure with it. See `08-print.md`

RL-BRAND-001-PRINT.

SEC.09

9 • THE AUTOMATED CHECK

`scripts/build.js` fails the build if:

- ▶ a `-deep` accent stops clearing 4.5:1 against bone
- ▶ `ink` on `orange` stops clearing 4.5:1
- ▶ any field's `-text` or `-text-muted` drops under 4.5:1 on that field, or its `-text-faint` drops under 3:1 – the `color-mix()` steps are resolved first
- ▶ any contrast figure printed in the docs, the stylesheet comments, `tokens.json` or the specimen stops matching a ratio the generated reference actually publishes
- ▶ any `border-radius` other than 0 appears
- ▶ any `box-shadow` gains a blur radius
- ▶ `tokens.json` and `riposte-brand.css` disagree on a hex value
- ▶ `riposte.ase` stops round-tripping

It does **not** check your markup. Contrast maths is automatable; whether you put a paragraph on a teal fill is not. That one's on you.

BASH

```
| node scripts/build.js --check
```

SOURCE docs/07-accessibility.tex SHA bf6b3fec7253 BUILT 2026-09-07